

Leading Through Change: My AI Integration Leadership Philosophy

A leadership philosophy & story bank, built from applied coursework in AI/ML integration and change management

I believe leading people through AI-driven change is less about mastering the technology and more about mastering the transition itself, reading a team's culture, making ethical calls before technical ones, and staying adaptive when the plan meets reality. Technology changes fast; how people experience that change determines whether it actually sticks.

Core Principles

1. Lead with culture awareness first

Before introducing new AI/ML tools, I try to understand how a team works day-to-day, its norms, its trust levels, and its unspoken resistance points. This is consistently one of my strongest self-assessed leadership skills, and I believe it's foundational: a technically perfect rollout still fails if it ignores the culture it's landing in.

2. Decide ethically before deciding technically

When evaluating an AI/ML solution, I ask 'should we' before 'can we.' Ethical and responsible AI use was my highest-scoring leadership competency, and I see it as a non-negotiable filter that must come before any conversation about model accuracy or ROI.

3. Read the room before you lead it

Change creates anxiety, even when it's positive. My strength in emotional intelligence shapes how I introduce change: naming the discomfort openly rather than pretending it isn't there, and adjusting my approach based on how people are actually responding, not how I expected them to respond.

4. Stay adaptive, not rigid

Plans rarely survive first contact with real implementation. I've learned through both coursework and reflection that the leaders who succeed are the ones who treat a change plan as a starting hypothesis, not a fixed script, and who build in checkpoints to revise course as new information comes in.

Where I'm Still Growing

I hold these principles alongside an honest accounting of my gaps. My self-assessments identified clear growth areas: AI/ML project management, translating technical AI concepts for non-technical stakeholders, and formal change management frameworks. I don't have hands-on professional experience managing a large-scale AI/ML rollout yet, and I'd rather be transparent about that than overstate my readiness. I'm treating these as active development areas, not blind spots I'm unaware of.

Story Bank

Three STAR-format stories drawn directly from this term's applied AI/ML coursework:

Story 1: Learning a new technical skill quickly

Situation: I was assigned to design and build a functional AI tool for my graduate AI/ML coursework, despite having no prior experience building or deploying a chatbot or AI agent.

Task: Apply generative AI tools and design thinking methodology to solve a real problem in my professional field, financial variance analysis.

Action: I used the design thinking framework to scope the tool's purpose before writing any code or prompts, then wrote a system prompt enforcing sequential, branching diagnostic reasoning rather than a single flat response. I stress-tested it with deliberately vague and unplanned follow-up inputs to confirm it reasoned correctly under ambiguity.

Result: I built Fintell, a branded AI variance-investigation assistant that, during testing, generated sharper follow-up questions than I had explicitly scripted, evidence that it could reason within a framework, not just follow a script. It's now live in my professional portfolio.

Story 2: Making a judgment call between competing approaches

Situation: For a case study assignment, I needed to evaluate when machine learning versus deep learning is the right technical choice for a business problem.

Task: Select and justify two financial services use cases - one suited to traditional ML, one suited to deep learning, with real-world evidence.

Action: I researched how banks use Support Vector Machines for customer churn prediction versus how PayPal uses Recurrent Neural Networks for real-time fraud detection and built my argument around concrete tradeoffs: interpretability and data requirements versus adaptability to fast-evolving patterns.

Result: I produced a report that didn't just describe two algorithms, but made a clear, defensible recommendation matched to each business context, the exact kind of judgment call an FP&A or BI role requires when leadership asks 'should we use AI here, and if so, how?'

Story 3: Identifying and owning a knowledge gap

Situation: I completed two formal leadership self-assessments (AI/ML Integration Leadership and Change Management) as part of coursework, despite not having direct professional experience managing AI/ML initiatives.

Task: Score myself honestly rather than defaulting to inflated or safe answers, and reflect critically on what the results actually mean.

Action: Rather than guess confidently, I flagged where my ratings were closer to estimates than grounded self-knowledge and grounded my reflection in Kruger and Dunning's (1999) research on the limits of self-assessment accuracy, using it to interpret my own results more critically instead of taking them at face value.

Result: I walked away with a specific, credible list of growth areas (AI/ML project management, stakeholder communication, formal change frameworks) rather than a vague sense of "I should improve" and a habit of pairing self-assessment with outside evidence that I now apply generally.

Reference

Kruger, J., & Dunning, D. (1999). Unskilled and unaware of it: How difficulties in recognizing one's own incompetence lead to inflated self-assessments. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 77(6), 1121–1134.
<https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.77.6.1121>